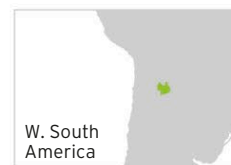


The Salar de Uyuni

The largest salt flat on Earth, the legacy of a huge prehistoric South American lake



Southwestern Bolivia's Salar de Uyuni is considered the planet's largest and least-polluted salt flat. Situated on a high plateau, around 4,100 square miles (10,600 square km) of salt, so fine it is almost flourlike, floats in a crust on top of a lake of brine thought to contain 50–70 percent of the world's lithium reserves. While around 25,000 tons (22,700 tonnes) of salt per year are harvested, a staggering 10 billion tons (9 billion tonnes) remain.

Islands in a white sea

The Salar de Uyuni's salt crust varies from a few inches to 33 ft (10 m) thick, reflecting the 6–65 ft (2–20 m) depth of the saltwater lake below it. Despite these variations, the crust's surface is remarkably flat, with less than 3 feet of difference in level from one side to the other. The vast expanse of white is not entirely unbroken, however. A few elevated areas, such as the cactus-covered Isla Incahuasi (Inca House Island), pierce the crust in places. For the most part, though, there is little vegetation. Some wildlife is present, mainly in the form of flamingos that migrate here to breed.

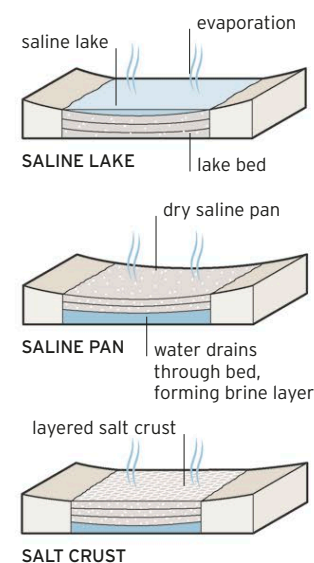
ROCKY OASIS

One of the few oases in an almost pure-white landscape, the rocky Isla Incahuasi supports the growth of tree-sized pasacana cacti, which can reach 33 ft (10 m) in height.



HOW SALT CRUSTS FORM

Salt pans form when the rate of evaporation of mineral-rich water is higher than the rate of precipitation. As the water dries up, the previously dissolved salt ions solidify, forming a hard white crust, which thickens as the process continues.



NATURAL GEOMETRY

When saline water evaporates undisturbed, hexagonal patterns are formed on the salt crusts. Widespread similar hexagons indicate calm conditions throughout the salar.

Ponds formed by rain **dissolve bumps** on the **salt flat's** surface

